

THE RISE OF Islam



▲ The hand of Fatima

This design, also known as the *khamsa*, is a stylized representation of a hand. A popular amulet in the Islamic world, its name may refer to the protection provided by devout women such as Fatima, the daughter of Prophet Muhammad.

7TH-CENTURY ARAB WORLD

Among the tribes of the Arabian peninsula in the 6th century CE, societal attitudes to women were complicated by traditions. Arab pagan men could take as many wives as they wanted and, in some tribes, newborn girls were valued so little that they were buried alive; early Islamic sources contain some harrowing accounts of Muslim converts lamenting their parts in such crimes. The rise of Islam fundamentally improved women's lives on the Arabian Peninsula. The faith originated there in 610 CE, when the Prophet Muhammad is said to have begun receiving revelations from God in a place called Makkah. During the next 23 years of his life, his teachings spread across the peninsula and, after his death the Islamic faith expanded rapidly thanks to invasion and conquest throughout North Africa, and as far as present-day Pakistan.

Rights and property

The new religion enshrined women's rights in its laws and also gave them privileges and freedoms. God declared in the Qur'an, Islam's sacred text, that women were spiritually equal to men, and the Prophet Muhammad treated women with reverence. However, these laws were also affected by the male-dominant cultures brought under Islamic rule.

The Qur'an prescribed laws that protected the social position of women. While polygamy was not outlawed, a man was permitted a maximum of four wives, with the proviso that, "if you fear you will not be fair, then only one." The limitations on polygamy were considered radical by many early followers of the Prophet. Women's property rights were also enshrined in the Qur'an. Women inherited half of a brother's

share on the death of her parents, but whereas a man had to use his share to care for his family, a woman was able to keep hers entirely for herself. Qur'anic law gave women the right to consent to marriage and also the right to

Muhammad's

11

wives were
called **Mothers
of the Faithful**

